

IG 1 VISION

We envision IG 1 to be a place where our members are welcomed, encouraged, and challenged as we focus on growing in our love for Jesus together. We strive for this community to be one that mutually inspires one another to pursue Christ deeper, with an emphasis on personal devotion alongside the support and unity as a small group and larger fellowship. Knowing how easy it can be to get distracted in our pursuit of God, and how challenging it can be to stay grounded in one's faith, especially in the temporal world we live in, we hope IG 1 will become a community where, together, we *"seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness"* (Matthew 6:33).

These are three characteristics we want to cultivate within our IG:

- 1) Sharing the Love of Christ
- 2) Vulnerable, Fruitful, and Honest Conversations
- 3) Accountability to Grow in Faith

1) Sharing the Love of Christ

IG 1 begins with inviting new people in & reaching out to others, ultimately for the sake of sharing the gospel through both our words and actions. We aspire to create a community where everyone is embraced with Christ-like love, creating space for genuine transformation and connection. This means not only greeting others heartily, but also cultivating an atmosphere where each person feels seen, known, and valued. We understand that welcoming others is more than a momentary action, but rather an ongoing attitude. With this in mind, we hope that choosing to love others in action is not restricted to our IG, nor just within CCF or the church, but extends to the broader campus and community, for the reason that God's love may be known.

"A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another. By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another." - John 13:34-35

"Therefore welcome one another as Christ has welcomed you, for the glory of God" - Romans 15:7

As leaders, we carry the responsibility of setting the tone for the fellowship, modelling a heart of welcome, openness, and inclusion. Practically, we can do so by initiating introductions and engaging in intentional icebreaker activities. We can also achieve this through deliberate follow-up and staying connected with newcomers to continue building faith-filled relationships. By reaching out after gatherings and inviting others into a deeper community, we nurture relationships that reflect God's continual pursuit of us.

2) Vulnerable, Fruitful, and Honest Conversations

We aim for IG 1 to be a place where people can be open with one another about their struggles, burdens, and opinions. Words have the potential to make immense impacts (cf. James 2), meaning how and what we discuss will shape much of what our small group becomes. We hope to speak the truth in love (cf. Ephesians 4:15), resulting in gospel-filled, fruitful, and honest conversations. In addition to cultivating graceful and truthful speech, we believe that mutual confessions of sin and prayers are essential to any fellowship:

"Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working." - James 5:16

Scripture makes it clear that healing and fortitude come through transparency and prayer. In IG 1, we seek to embody this truth in how we support one another. The purpose of creating such an environment is to cultivate deeper godly friendships, spur each other on to do good, and carry one another's burdens, as God commanded us.

"Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ." - Galatians 6:2

In doing this, we fulfill a command along with the essence of Christ's teachings. Additionally, in being vulnerable and transparent about our weakness, we remember that Jesus deals gently with the ignorant and wayward, understanding our struggles (cf. Hebrews 5:2). Practically speaking, we want to be intentional with every IG Bible study and night through smaller group applications and prayers. We hope to make sharing and asking for prayer requests a norm within the IG, which starts with initiating these conversations ourselves. Lastly, we hope to create an open and honest space for eventual testimony sharings during IG nights, which will translate into opportunities for our members to share life reflections through more meaningful icebreaker questions and conversations.

3) Accountability to Grow in Faith

As we envision IG 1 to be not only welcoming and vulnerable, we also seek to hold one another accountable in our spiritual disciplines for the sake of growing in wisdom and reverence for God. We may all be at different points in our spiritual journeys, but we recognize the fundamental importance of God's Word and prayer.

Growing in wisdom and grace is foundational to our lives as Christians:

"But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ." - 2 Peter 3:18a

Supporting one another in our faith is also critical to our spiritual growth:

"But exhort one another every day, as long as it is called 'today,' that none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin" (Hebrews 3:13).

We read about how "Iron sharpens iron, and one man sharpens another" (Proverbs 27:17), making accountability a principal practice we hope to establish. Specifically, we hope to, in due course, start plans to encourage scripture reading and to use our group chat as an accountability space for devotions. We also wish to extend fellowship beyond Friday nights, including during reading weeks and exam seasons, and encourage members to participate in greater CCF and church activities to further live out the gospel. We acknowledge that these practices to grow accountability might be implemented gradually over time, as building a connected community within the IG is our primary undertaking.

Ultimately, we hope IG 1 becomes a community of believers and friends who mutually welcome and encourage one another, are open and vulnerable, and hold each other accountable to the faith we have in Jesus Christ. We intend to begin with seeking God first in our own lives and letting our leadership be a reflection of the love of God that is in our hearts. We pray that as an IG, we will all learn from one another and from God Himself, how to pursue Him more deeply and purposefully in our lives.

Peace out,
Brian & Rachel